Humayun's brothers, not just Kamran, were either dead or exiled, if not by Humayun's doing, then in the service of his ambition. Far from sharing an empire with them, as their father might have hoped, he had lost his inheritance and snatched what remained for himself. If guilt spoiled some of the pleasure of being the unchallenged master of Kabul, it would be unsurprising.

There is no record of what Akbar felt about his father's triumph in the war between brothers that began before Akbar was born, no record of what he felt about his uncle's friendless end, and certainly no record of Akbar's feelings when, in Kabul that spring, Humayun's youngest wife gave birth to Humayun's second son. If Akbar looked upon his newborn half-brother and saw, already, a sword and shield in his little fists, that would be unsurprising – but Akbar kept any such thoughts to himself.

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Perhaps he had no time for such forebodings. By the following year, in the winter of 1554, Kabul was abuzz with news from Hindustan. Salim Shah Suri[68] was dead. Salim's father, Sher Shah, had died almost a decade earlier, having achieved a lifetime's worth in his five brief years of rule – from occupying Ranthambore and Chittorgarh without battle to introducing a standardized 'rupee'. When Sher Shah choked to death in the smoke of explosives during a siege, he was succeeded by his son, who kept the Suri empire stable and, more recently, quashed Kamran's hopes for an alliance. Salim's own son, however, was a child when the shah died, and was murdered almost immediately by his uncle. A fractious battle for succession had begun, the Suri dynasty might well be in collapse, and it was the perfect time for rival claimants to swoop down upon Hindustan. In short, would Humayun march east and win his throne back?

He would; he did.

In mid-November 1554,[69] Humayun left Kabul with an army of 3000 men. Among them were some old familiars: Tardi Beg, no doubt hoping to recover what treasure he'd lost during Humayun's decline; Muazzam, Hamida's younger brother and one-time sleuth; Shamsuddin Ataka, Akbar's faithful foster father; even Babus, that most tragic of turncoats; and, of course, Bairam Khan, who had kept guard over Qandahar these past years.